their experiences," says Dr Upasana Chaddha, founder of Delhi-based Mindscape Counselling. She adds that though victims are usually unsure of whether they were drugged, she has had patients who say they felt "more drunk than usual" before the assault.

Currently, Gamma Hydroxybutyrate or GHB (also called Liquid X, Easy Lay, Fantasy), Flunitrazepam or Rohypnol (commonly known as Roofies or Forget-me-Pill), and Ketamine (also called Special K or Vitamin K) are the three most common date rape drugs. They are banned in India.

High-quantity seizures are also common. In 2019, the Indian Coast Guard seized 1,160 kg of Ketamine worth Rs 300 crore on a Myanmarese ship off the Car Nicobar islands. The cargo was reportedly being supplied to another boat near the Thailand-Malaysia maritime borderline. In 2018, GHB worth Rs 18 lakh was confiscated in Hyderabad; in May this year, in Rajasthan's Ajmer, a man was arrested for attempting to send Ketamine worth Rs 3 crore to the US by post.



"PARENTS ARE OFTEN IN DENIAL, THEY THINK THEIR CHILD IS STILL YOUNG, DOESN'T GO ON DATES, AND SO ON. THEY DON'T WANT TO HAVE HONEST CONVERSATIONS"

SUNITA GEORGE
Principal, Bombay Scottish School, Mumbai

A FACT SHEET ON DATE RAPE DRUGS

Given below are the three most common date rape drugs, also known as 'party drugs' or 'club drugs'. Since they have no colour, taste or smell, how you feel after consuming them is an important way to tell whether you have been drugged, or 'roofied'

LIQUID X/ EASY LAY/ FANTASY
Known by several street names, GHB (Gamma Hydroxybutyrate) is medically prescribed for narcolepsy and makes the user feel weak, drowsy and forgetful. It is not available over the counter, but one can find detailed guides on the internet about making GHB at home using commonly available chemicals. The drug can also cause seizures, unconsciousness, slow heartbeat and coma if consumed in high doses.



ROOFIES/ FORGET-ME-PILLS
Flunitrazepam, or Rohypnol, belongs to a class of tranquilisers and has a relaxing effect. In higher doses, however, it can lead to amnesia or loss of consciousness.

SPECIAL K/ VITAMIN K: Ketamine has a strong dissasociative effect. The effects start within 30 minutes of consumption and last an hour or two, though sometimes they may be felt for a day or more.

COMMON SIGNS

- Mental confusion and a feeling that you are getting too drunk, too fast
- Sudden loss of balance and difficulty walking straight
- Impaired speech or slurring
- Extreme drowsiness
- Vision issues and difficulty focusing on anything

HOW TO STAY SAFE

According to a study published in 2017 by the US-based Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC), around 11 million women in the country have been raped while they were drunk or drugged. The United States has the highest number of such cases anywhere in the world, and since 1996, it has had a federal law against the use of date rape drugs, increasing the penalty for abusers who drugged their victims.

Consequently, a number of safety devices are now available in the country. A company called DrinkSavvy has invented a set of cups and straws that change colour upon coming in contact with GHB, roofies or Ketamine. Another device, SipChip, looks like a small coin and can test a drink in 30 seconds with high accuracy. Also available are a pen drive, smart coasters